



What is Puberty?

Puberty is an exciting time when your body starts to change, getting ready for adulthood. These changes don't happen all at once, and they're different for everyone. Hormones—special chemicals in your body—play a huge role in how your body grows and develops during this time.

For Girls:

For girls, the hormone called **estrogen** is especially important. It helps your body grow taller, develop breasts, and get ready to eventually start your period.

For Boys:

Boys have a hormone called **testosterone** that helps them grow taller, build muscle, and develop deeper voices.

It can feel like a lot at once, but remember: your body is doing exactly what it's supposed to.

These changes are part of becoming a teenager and, eventually, an adult.

Everyone's body grows differently, so even if your friends aren't going through the same changes yet, it doesn't mean anything is wrong.





When Does Puberty Start?

Puberty usually begins between the ages of **8 and 13** for girls and **9 to 14** for boys, but it's different for everyone. Some people might notice changes earlier, and some might start a little later. This is totally normal!

Several factors can influence when puberty starts:

- **Genetics:** Your family plays a big role. If your parents started puberty earlier or later, you might too.
- **Nutrition:** Eating healthy helps your body grow, and nutrition can affect how your body develops.
- **Overall Health:** Staying active and taking care of your body can help it develop properly during puberty.

Everyone's body grows at its own pace, and no two experiences are exactly alike.





Differences Between Male and Female Puberty

While this book focuses on the changes you're going through as a girl, boys also experience puberty—though their journey is a little different. Understanding these differences can help you relate better to the boys in your life—whether they're friends, classmates, or siblings.

Here's a quick look at what boys go through during puberty:

- **Voice Changes:** Boys' voices become deeper, but not all at once. You might hear their voices "crack" or shift in pitch before it settles into a deeper tone.
- **Facial and Body Hair:** Boys begin growing hair on their face (like mustaches and beards) and may develop more hair on their chest and legs.
- **Growth Spurts:** Just like girls, boys experience rapid growth in height, though it often happens a little later. Their bodies also start building more muscle during this time.
- **Emotional Changes:** Boys also experience emotional shifts, like mood swings or feelings of awkwardness, especially as they adjust to the changes in their bodies.

These changes can sometimes affect how boys and girls interact with each other. You might notice boys becoming more awkward or self-conscious about their bodies, just as you might feel at times. By understanding what boys are going through, you'll have more empathy and be less likely to feel confused by the changes in their behavior. Social interactions during this time might feel different, but remember that both boys and girls are figuring things out as they grow.



First Signs of Puberty for Girls

As a girl, some of the **first signs of puberty** you might notice include:

- **Breast Development:** Your breasts will start to grow, beginning with small lumps under your nipples called breast buds. This can sometimes feel tender or sore, which is perfectly normal.
- **Growth Spurts:** You might suddenly find yourself growing taller quickly! Your body may feel different, and some girls feel a little clumsy as they adjust to their new height.
- **Body Hair:** Hair will start to grow in new places, like under your arms and in your pubic area. This is completely normal and happens to everyone at different times.
- **Emotional Changes:** Sometimes, puberty affects how you feel. You might notice your emotions swinging from happy to sad more quickly than usual. This is all part of how your body reacts to the hormones it's producing.

PUBERTY

Myth or Fact?

MYTH

- ❖ Everyone will notice when my body starts to change.
- ❖ I'll start my period as soon as my breasts start to grow.

- 🌸 Puberty happens gradually, and most people won't notice the small changes right away. Everyone is focused on their own experience, so you don't need to worry!
- 🌸 While breast development is an early sign of puberty, it usually takes a few years after this for your period to start. Every girl's timeline is different.

FACT



Embrace the Changes

Puberty can feel like a big change, but it's important to remember that these changes are normal and help your body grow exactly as it's meant to. Here's what we've learned:

- Puberty happens at different times for everyone.
- Boys and girls experience different changes, but we all grow together.
- Your body's changes are influenced by genetics, nutrition, and overall health.

Most importantly, **embrace these changes!** Your body is doing amazing things to help you grow into the best version of yourself.

